

More Permissive, More Populist?

Electoral Permissiveness and the Translation of Anti-Elite Attitudes into Votes

Melvin Ongaro

Writing Sample

Word count: 1,932 (excluding captions, notes, references and Table 1)

1. Introduction

Populist parties gain larger vote shares on average under proportional representation than under plurality rule in single-member districts (Becher et al., 2023; Self & Hicken, 2018). The usual explanation is strategic coordination: in single-member districts with a plurality of votes, voters are likely to vote for the most likely winner. Thus, supporters of smaller parties are likely to abandon their preferred party in order to support one with a greater chance of winning (Duverger, 1954; Cox, 1997). In this logic, populist parties, which are often smaller and less established than their main competitors, are more likely to receive few votes in such districts. If there is any truth to the voter-side coordination argument, then the relationship between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting will be stronger in districts of larger size.

This paper uses two complementary designs to test that mechanism. The first is a cross-national design using a multilevel logit model covering 42 election studies in 33 countries from the Module 5 dataset of the CSES (Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, 2023). The second is a within-respondent comparison of Swiss voters who took part in both a proportional National Council election and a majoritarian Council of States election at the same time.

Neither design provides the result predicted by the hypothesis. In the cross-national analysis, the interaction is not statistically different from zero, and its sign runs against the prediction. In the Swiss comparison, the interaction is positive, but the estimate is too imprecise to draw a clear conclusion. Taken together, these findings suggest that the higher aggregate support for populist parties under more permissive electoral rules is unlikely to be driven mainly by a stronger conversion of anti-elite attitudes into populist votes.

2. Theory and hypotheses

Duverger (1954) introduced two mechanisms for the plurality rule in single-member districts leading to two-party competition. The first is a mechanical effect of the winner-take-all rule, which systematically limits the representation of smaller relative to larger, established parties. The second effect is psychological, as voters wish to avoid "wasting" their vote by casting it for a party with little chance of winning. Cox (1997) extended this work as a problem of electoral coordination in which a district with M seats can sustain roughly $M+1$ viable competitors. District magnitude, understood as the number of seats in a district, has therefore become the central measure for the degree of permissiveness in a country's electoral system (Taagepera & Shugart, 1989). Evidence from the radical right also fits this argument, as studies

have found larger vote shares under more permissive rules (Becher et al., 2023; Carter, 2002; Golder, 2003).

It is well established that anti-elite attitudes are highly predictive of support for populist parties across countries (Van Hauwaert & Van Kessel, 2018). However, assessing the individual-level claim requires a different type of analysis: we must see how the same individuals translate the same attitudes into votes under different electoral rules. If these matter for this translation, in our statistical model, the relationship between the relevant attitudes and votes for populist parties will be interacted with the rules. In restrictive systems, the voters most interested in a populist party have the greatest incentive to desert it, hence the relationship should be flat; in permissive systems, the same voters have less of an incentive to desert a populist party, hence the relationship should be steeper.

Our two designs test the same hypothesis from different angles. The cross-national study contains strong institutional variation, while the Swiss design compares two ballots cast by the same respondent on the same day. Still, H2 should not be interpreted as a pure effect of the electoral formula. Even in Switzerland, the two ballots differ in other respects, including how candidate-centred they are, how the ballot is structured, and which parties compete (Ladner, 2014). The two relationships estimated by the two designs should therefore be seen as associations.

H1. The association between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting is stronger in electoral systems with high district magnitudes.

H2. Among the same Swiss voters, the association between anti-elite attitudes and voting for the Swiss People's Party is stronger on the proportional National Council ballot than on the majoritarian Council of States ballot.

3. Data and methodology

CSES Module 5 consists of 56 post-election surveys conducted between 2016 and 2021. The dependent variable is a vote for a populist party in the lower-house election. We consider a party to be populist if it receives a rating of 7 or higher on the 0 to 10 scale (Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, 2023). We require a minimum of 300 usable respondents and five populist votes in each study. After listwise deletion, 42 studies across 33 countries and involving a total of 53,230 respondents are retained. Since systems with low district magnitude tend to have lower proportions of populist votes, this rule may disproportionately exclude cases from these systems and thus reduce the ability to find evidence in support of H1.

The measure of populist attitudes used in this study is based on five items of the CSES Module 5 anti-elite battery (Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, 2023). It captures a strong anti-elite sentiment but does not measure people-centrism or the Manichaeian worldview that the full ideational definition also includes (Mudde, 2004). Hence, all claims made in this study about populist attitudes refer to the anti-elite part of these attitudes. The resulting scale is

standardised within the cross-national sample so that one unit corresponds to one standard deviation of anti-elite attitudes. Internal reliability ranges from 0.452 to 0.862 across studies. Electoral permissiveness, the explanatory variable, is operationalised as the natural log of the median district magnitude for the respondents in each study.

The main model is a multilevel logit with random intercepts and random slopes for the anti-elite attitudes in each election study. It includes an interaction between attitudes and log district magnitude. The controls include age, gender, level of education, position on the left-right political spectrum, satisfaction with democracy, and whether a populist party had held cabinet positions before the election.

Although 53,230 cases are observed, the effective number of upper-level units is the number of countries (33). Multilevel models are known to estimate cross-level interactions imprecisely when that number is small (Stegmueller, 2013; Bryan & Jenkins, 2016).

4. Cross-national results

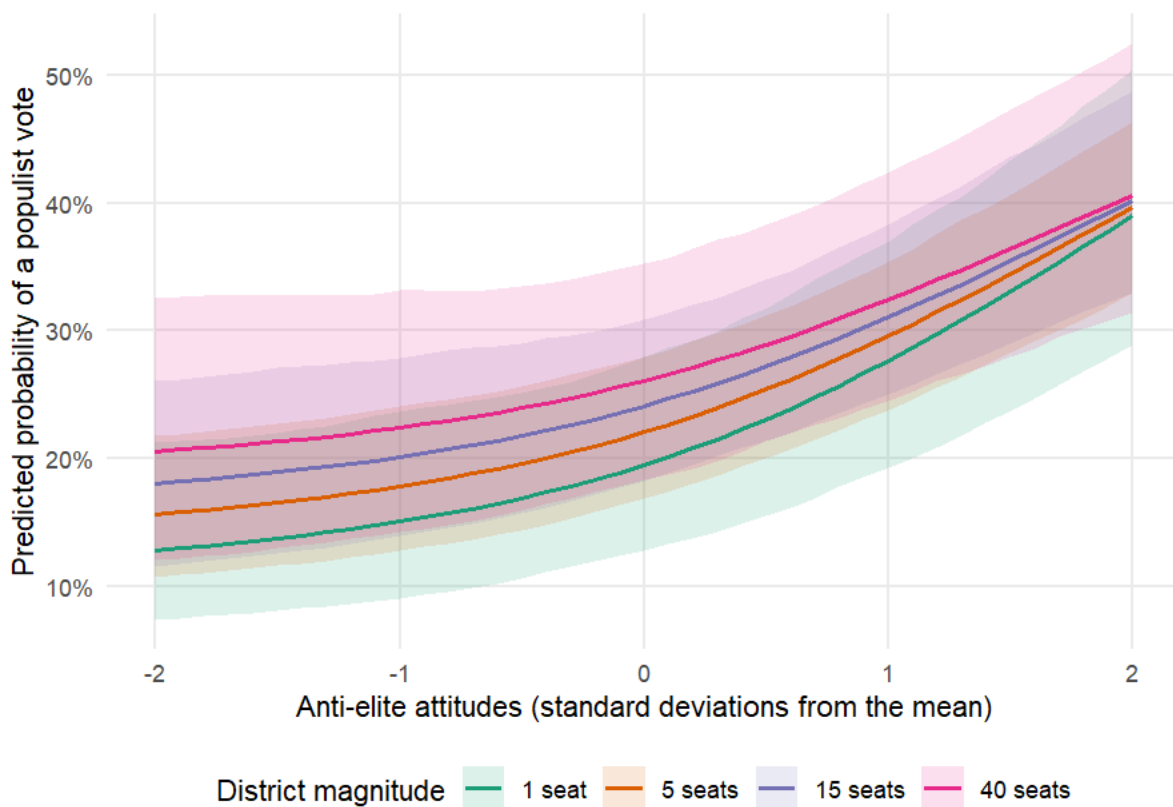
Anti-elite attitudes are a strong predictor of populist voting, with a coefficient of 0.553 (0.089). The main question is whether that relationship changes with district magnitude. The cross-level interaction is -0.052 (0.053), and its 95% confidence interval ranges from -0.156 to 0.052 (Table 1). Its sign runs against H1. The estimate does not provide evidence for the predicted moderation.

In terms of predicted probabilities, increasing anti-elite attitudes by one standard deviation raises the probability of a populist vote by 6.1 percentage points in a one-seat district, 5.8 points at five seats, 5.4 at 15 seats, and 5.0 at 40 seats (Figure 1). The analysis tells us more about what a strong demand-side interaction is unlikely to be than about smaller effects.

The result is similar in the robustness checks. When magnitude is measured at the respondent's own district rather than by the study median, the interaction is 0.013 (0.026), opposite in sign to the main specification and again indistinguishable from zero. The interaction is still -0.056 (0.051) at a threshold of 6 and -0.051 (0.054) at a threshold of 8.

These results indicate that the institutional variable used here does not account for differences in the attitude-vote slope across studies, where the random slope variance is 0.290. The cross-national result should thus be understood as evidence against a large positive moderation, but not against every smaller effect.

Figure 1. Predicted probability of a populist vote by anti-elite attitudes and district magnitude.



Note: Population-averaged predictions, controls at sample means and random effects integrated out by parametric simulation. Bands are 95% confidence intervals.

5. The Swiss test

Switzerland's 2019 post-electoral study is part of the cross-national sample. The Swiss analysis only includes respondents who cast valid votes in both the lower-house National Council and upper-house Council of States elections. The within-respondent design fixes all respondents' characteristics constant between ballots. However, the design does not isolate the effect of the electoral formula. The two electoral arrangements differ not only in electoral formula but also in candidate-centredness, ballot design, number of votes, and parties and candidates that run in the election.

Ladner (2014) compares candidates from the same party who ran for the two chambers in the same election and finds no greater degree of moderation displayed by Council of States candidates than by their National Council counterparts. Therefore, any party difference observed at the chamber level is unlikely to stem from differences between candidates of the same party.

The Swiss People's Party (SVP) is the only Swiss party rated 7 or higher on the CSES populism scale. Anti-elite attitudes predict an SVP vote at 1.333 (0.221), while the proportional ballot has a positive coefficient of 0.688 (0.162). The interaction between attitudes and the proportional ballot is 0.182 (0.154), with a 95% interval from -0.119 to 0.483 (Table 1).

A conditional logit stratified by respondent gives an attitude-by-ballot interaction of 0.084 (0.147). The interaction is smaller than in the multilevel model and remains far from conventional levels of statistical significance.

The main limitation of the Swiss test is the number of respondents who actually change their choice. The ballot coefficient and its interaction with attitudes are identified by the 209 respondents, out of 2,499, whose SVP choice differs across ballots. The absence of a significant interaction in this design is best read as inconclusive, not as evidence that no such interaction exists.

Table 1. The two interaction estimates across specifications.

Specification	Interaction	95% interval	p	N
H1, main specification (study median magnitude)	-0.052 (0.053)	[-0.156, 0.052]	0.330	53,230
H1, respondent's own district magnitude	0.013 (0.026)	[-0.037, 0.064]	0.602	53,116
H1, populist threshold at 6	-0.056 (0.051)	[-0.157, 0.044]	0.269	57,412
H1, populist threshold at 8	-0.051 (0.054)	[-0.156, 0.054]	0.344	45,552
H2, main specification (multilevel logit)	0.182 (0.154)	[-0.119, 0.483]	0.236	4,998
H2, conditional logit stratified by respondent	0.084 (0.147)	[-0.205, 0.373]	0.571	4,998

Note: Each row is the interaction coefficient from a separate model, with standard error, 95% confidence interval, p-value and observations. H1 rows report the anti-elite $\times$ log-magnitude product. H2 rows report the anti-elite $\times$ proportional-ballot product. All coefficients are in log-odds.

6. Discussion and conclusion

While the relationship between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting is strong in both studies, there is no strong evidence that this relationship is even stronger under more permissive electoral rules. The cross-national interaction is close to zero and its confidence interval does not allow for strong positive moderation. The Swiss interaction is positive but imprecise and becomes smaller in the conditional logit. Therefore, the cross-national design provides evidence against a large positive moderation, while the Swiss design remains inconclusive.

Interpreting the results as evidence that district magnitude has no effect on populist voting would go beyond what the analysis can establish. Under the Swiss proportional ballot, the SVP performs better at any given level of anti-elite attitudes than under the majoritarian ballot system.

Several limitations need to be noted. First, the five CSES items for anti-elite attitudes do not measure populism in its conceptual entirety. Furthermore, the upper-level analysis consists of 42 studies from 33 countries and not 53,230 individual cases. This upper-level sample limits the precision of the cross-level interaction term. Third, district magnitude serves only as a proxy for the broader concept of electoral permissiveness. It does not capture a number of further factors such as electoral formula, legal threshold, or list structure. Finally, the anti-elite attitudes are measured in post-election interviews, thus the analysis cannot conclude that these attitudes in fact predated the voting in the causal sequence of interest.

These results make a large voter-side coordination effect, operating specifically through the anti-elite attitude-vote link, an unlikely explanation for why permissive rules favour populist

parties. Hence, our results do not allow us to attribute the favouring of populist parties by permissive rules to the interaction of these rules with the populist options in the electoral supply. To test this alternative explanation, data on the entry and positioning of parties in different electoral contexts would be required, alongside the attitude data that was used in this design.

Overall, the evidence indicates that electoral permissiveness does not systematically alter the strength of the relationship between anti-elite attitudes and populist voting. It suggests that electoral-supply and other contextual mechanisms deserve greater attention as explanations of cross-system differences in populist success.

References

- Becher, M., Menéndez González, I., & Stegmueller, D. (2023). Proportional representation and right-wing populism: Evidence from electoral system change in Europe. *British Journal of Political Science*, 53(1), 261–268. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0007123421000703>
- Bryan, M. L., & Jenkins, S. P. (2016). Multilevel modelling of country effects: A cautionary tale. *European Sociological Review*, 32(1), 3–22. <https://doi.org/10.1093/esr/jcv059>
- Carter, E. (2002). Proportional representation and the fortunes of right-wing extremist parties. *West European Politics*, 25(3), 125–146. <https://doi.org/10.1080/713601617>
- Comparative Study of Electoral Systems. (2023). *CSES Module 5 full release [Dataset and documentation]*, 25 July 2023 version. <https://doi.org/10.7804/cses.module5.2023-07-25>
- Cox, G. W. (1997). *Making votes count: Strategic coordination in the world's electoral systems*. Cambridge University Press.
- Duverger, M. (1954). *Political parties: Their organization and activity in the modern state*. Wiley.
- Golder, M. (2003). Explaining variation in the success of extreme right parties in western Europe. *Comparative Political Studies*, 36(4), 432–466. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0010414003251176>
- Ladner, A. (2014). The impact of the electoral system on political campaigning: Are candidates for the Council of States more moderate than their fellow candidates for the National Council? *Swiss Political Science Review*, 20(4), 678–696. <https://doi.org/10.1111/spsr.12134>
- Mudde, C. (2004). The populist zeitgeist. *Government and Opposition*, 39(4), 541–563. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1477-7053.2004.00135.x>
- Self, D., & Hicken, A. (2018). *Why populism? How parties shape the electoral fortune of populists* (V-Dem Working Paper Series 2018:76). Varieties of Democracy Institute. <https://doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.3251696>
- Stegmueller, D. (2013). How many countries for multilevel modeling? A comparison of frequentist and Bayesian approaches. *American Journal of Political Science*, 57(3), 748–761. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12001>

- Taagepera, R., & Shugart, M. S. (1989). *Seats and votes: The effects and determinants of electoral systems*. Yale University Press.
- Van Hauwaert, S. M., & Van Kessel, S. (2018). Beyond protest and discontent: A cross-national analysis of the effect of populist attitudes and issue positions on populist party support. *European Journal of Political Research*, 57(1), 68–92.
<https://doi.org/10.1111/1475-6765.12216>